

PURPOSE AND PRIORITY OF FASTING

*** DENOTES POWER POINT PRESENTATION**

**** DENOTES INSTRUCTIONS TO TECHNICIAN**

INTRO: Today we are embarking upon a 21 day fast. As a result, I want to take this Sunday and next Sunday to establish a Scriptural basis for why we should fast and what we hope to accomplish in so doing.

Fasting is a Scriptural principle. **(LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE)** One hundred sixty times the Bible references the word fasting or some variation of it

The word fast means *one who has ~~not~~ eaten, one who is empty.* Our word *breakfast* simply means to break our time of fasting between the evening meal and morning meal. Sad to say, but that is about as much fasting as most Christians ever do.

People point to all kinds of excuses for not practicing the principle of fasting:

- Fasting makes me sick...
- I am not physically strong enough to fast...
- My schedule will not allow for fasting...
- Fasting is the responsibility of church leaders...

None of these excuses are a good reason for neglecting the discipline of fasting. My prayer is that before we are finished with this series we will see such benefit in this spiritual discipline that we will be motivated to participate at some level.

(LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE) Fasting is one of the most fruitful and productive things you can do.

During these lessons we are going to explore the following things:

- Fasting in the Old Testament and the New Testament...
- Why fast...
- When to fast...
- Types of fasts...

I. FASTING IN THE OLD TESTAMENT AND THE NEW TESTAMENT...

In Judaism the Day of Atonement was a time of complete fasting, this meant no food or water for twenty four hours. This was the only prescribed time of fasting and it was intended to be a day of national repentance. During the Day of Atonement the participants were to refrain from all labor. If one decided not to fast on this particular day the punishment was death.

The Old Testament employs the ~~word~~ *afflict* when describing the discipline of fasting. When we read that a person *afflicted, sanctified or consecrated themselves*, the Scripture is simply saying that they fasted.

Fasting in the Old Testament (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Pastor Moses fasted– (Fasted 40 days twice – The result; the ten commandments)
- The Children of Israel fasted– Judges 20, 1 Samuel 7, 1 Samuel 31, 2 Samuel 1
- King David fasted– 2 Samuel 12, Psalms 69, Psalms 109
- King Ahab fasted– 1 Kings 12
- The servants Saul fasted– 1 Chronicles 10

- The prophet Ezra fasted– Ezra 8&9
- Nehemiah fasted– Nehemiah 1 (He fasted until God sent him to Jerusalem to rebuild the broken city)
- Mordecai fasted– Esther 4 (Fasted for an intercessor)
- Zechariah and the priests fasted– Zechariah 7
- The prophet Daniel fasted– (Fasted 21 days before receiving an answer and visions) Daniel 9&10
- The prophet Joel fasted– Joel 2

History tells us; during the time between the Old Testament and the New Testament fasting became a Jewish characteristic or mark.

Fasting in the New Testament: (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- The Pharisees fasted
- Jesus fasted – Matthew 4, Mark 2, Mark 9 (This time of fasting prepared Him for public ministry)
- Anna fasted – Luke 2
- Cornelius fasted – Acts 10 (The Lord sent Peter to present the gift of the Holy Spirit to the gentile world)
- The Apostles fasted – Acts 13 (Paul and Barnabas are selected as the first missionaries of the New Testament church)
- Paul fasted – 2 Corinthians 6, 2 Corinthians 11

Fasting is both an Old Testament and New Testament principle and activity. If fasting is a New Testament principle it is certainly

worthy of the consideration of every Christian.

II. WHY FAST?

Let me begin this segment of this study by saying that fasting will not persuade God to do anything which He would not ordinarily do. If we are fasting to convince God to do a miracle we are wasting your time.

God already desires to give good things to His children. Matthew 7:11 (KJV) *"If you then, being evil, know how to give good gifts to your children, how much more will your Father who is in heaven give good things to those who ask Him!"* 2 Chronicles 16:9 (NKJV) *"For the eyes of the LORD run to and fro throughout the whole earth, to show Himself strong on behalf of those whose heart is loyal to Him..."*

If fasting does not convince God to do anything He would not ordinarily do, why fast? (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- The words of Jesus implore us to do so. Matthew 9:14-15 (NLT) *"One day the disciples of John the Baptist came to Jesus and asked him, 'Why do we and the Pharisees fast, but your disciples don't fast?'"* 15 Jesus responded, *"Should the wedding guests mourn while celebrating with the groom? Someday he will be taken from them, and then they will fast."*
- Fasting is the duty of every Christian. Matthew 6:16 (NLT) *"And when you fast, don't make it obvious, as the hypocrites do, who try to look pale and disheveled so people will admire them for their fasting. I assure you, that is the only reward they will ever get."*
- Fasting crucifies the flesh. The flesh is the enemy of faith and therefore it is the enemy of God. Galatians 5:16-26 (NLT) *"So I advise you to live according to your new life in the Holy Spirit. Then you won't be doing what your sinful nature craves. 17 The old*

sinful nature loves to do evil, which is just opposite from what the Holy Spirit wants. And the Spirit gives us desires that are opposite from what the sinful nature desires. These two forces are constantly fighting each other, and your choices are never free from this conflict. 18 But when you are directed by the Holy Spirit, you are no longer subject to the law. 19 When you follow the desires of your sinful nature, your lives will produce these evil results: sexual immorality, impure thoughts, eagerness for lustful pleasure, 20 idolatry, participation in demonic activities, hostility, quarreling, jealousy, outbursts of anger, selfish ambition, divisions, the feeling that everyone is wrong except those in your own little group, 21 envy, drunkenness, wild parties, and other kinds of sin. Let me tell you again, as I have before, that anyone living that sort of life will not inherit the Kingdom of God. 22 But when the Holy Spirit controls our lives, he will produce this kind of fruit in us: love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, 23 gentleness, and self-control. Here there is no conflict with the law. 24 Those who belong to Christ Jesus have nailed the passions and desires of their sinful nature to his cross and crucified them there. 25 If we are living now by the Holy Spirit, let us follow the Holy Spirit's leading in every part of our lives. 26 Let us not become conceited, or irritate one another, or be jealous of one another."

- **Fasting humbles the believer before God.** If we fast a few days we find that we are more humble than ever before.

- Fasting teaches the believer dependence upon God as his source
- Fasting expresses submission to God Submission to God helps us appreciate the need of self-denial **Matthew 6:10 NKJV**) *"Your kingdom come. Your will be done On earth as it is in heaven."*
- Fasting prepares us to receive revelation from God (Moses, David, Nehemiah and Daniel)
- Fasting brings victory To be Christ like **life** of victory. Doubt is of the flesh, refusal to crucify the flesh brings defeat. When **crucify** the flesh we have victory.
- Fasting places the believer in a positioning from God.– (Daniel)

III. WHEN TO FAST...

The timing of a fast is probably as crucial decision to fast.

(LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE) not to fast just for the exercise of it, we are to fast in an attempt to crucify the flesh and move closer to God.

There are times when a believer feels a special need to draw closer to the Lord. This is the Spirit moving within our hearts letting us know that we need to do something out of the ordinary to meet God on His **terms** **James 4:5-10 (KJV)** ***"Do ye think that the scripture saith in vain, The spirit that dwelleth in us lusteth to envy? 6 But he giveth more grace. Wherefore he saith, God resisteth the proud, but giveth grace unto the humble. 7 Submit yourselves therefore to God. Resist the devil, and he will flee from you. 8 Draw nigh to God, and he will draw nigh to you. Cleanse your hands, ye sinners; and purify your hearts, ye double minded. 9 Be afflicted, and mourn,***

and weep: let your laughter be turned to mourning, and your joy to heaviness. 10 Humble yourselves in the sight of the Lord, and he shall lift you up.”

The best way to get on God’s turf is to crucify **(LEAVE; ON SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE)** the most effective method

of crucifying the flesh is through fasting Galatians 5:16-26 (CEV) *“If you are guided by the Spirit, you won’t obey your selfish desires. 17 The Spirit and your desires are enemies of each other. They are always fighting each other and keeping you from doing what you feel you should. 18 But if you obey the Spirit, the Law of Moses has no control over you. 19 People’s desires make them give in to immoral ways, filthy thoughts, and shameful deeds. 20 They worship idols, practice witchcraft, hate others, and are hard to get along with. People become jealous, angry, and selfish. They not only argue and cause trouble, but they are 21 envious. They get drunk, carry on at wild parties, and do other evil things as well. I told you before, and I am telling you again: No one who does these things will share in the blessings of God’s kingdom. 22 God’s Spirit makes us loving, happy, peaceful, patient, kind, good, faithful, 23 gentle, and self-controlled. There is no law against behaving in any of these ways. 24 And because we belong to Christ Jesus, we have killed our selfish feelings and desires. (I call fasting dying!) 25 God’s Spirit has given us life, and so we should follow the Spirit. 26 But don’t be conceited or make others jealous by claiming to be better than they are.”*

We should fast (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- **When God lays a fast on hearts.** We should be sensitive to what the Spirit is saying. If we are constantly

feeding the flesh and starving the spirit we will not feel the need to fast. (2,000 pound gorilla in the back yard)

- **When our prayer life needs strengthened** Fasting will enhance our prayer life like we cannot believe. It is in this setting we can sense the nearness of His presence. (Over the years some church members have done wonders for my prayer life!)
- **When we need to prepare ourselves to God's message.** This is probably the greatest benefit of fasting. Oftentimes it is difficult to hear from God during the fast but after the fast hearing from God is not difficult at all. **Luke 4:13** (NKJV) *"Now when the devil had ended every temptation, he departed from Him until an opportune time."*
- **When we become addicted in our spirit.** Fasting brings a heightened intimacy.
- **When we are experiencing crisis in our life.** I have made it a practice not to make major decisions without a minimum of three days fasting. (Experience in Fouke – Three and a half days and I received my answer)
- **When spiritual leaders call a fast.** This is probably the most difficult fast to embark upon because our response seems more of a response to man than to God. **Joel 1:14** (NKJV) *"Consecrate a fast, Call a sacred assembly; Gather the elders And all the inhabitants of the land Into the house of the LORD your God, And cry out to the LORD."* **Hebrews 13:17** (NKJV) *"Obey those who rule over you, and be submissive, for they watch out for your souls, as those who must give account. Let them do so with joy and not with grief, for that would be unprofitable for you."*

Fasting is a very difficult decision to reach but it is probably one of the most important disciplines in the Christian life.

IV. TYPES OF FASTING...

Let's take a look at the different types of fasting in the Bible. I don't want you to feel intimidated or overwhelmed by the thought of going without food for days on end. There are types of fasting that don't involve such a radical commitment. The Bible gives examples of many different kinds of fasting. The terms I will use to describe the different types of fasts are not biblical terms they are terms I have chosen to describe Biblical methods of fasting. Let's look at them:)PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Radical fast – This is a fast that includes neither food nor water. This is the type of fast which Jesus and Moses went on. This type of fast can be risky to one's health. One should make sure God is telling one to embark upon such an odyssey. I would not recommend this fast for more than a maximum of three days and then only with a Doctor's approval.
- Absolute fast – This is when we consume no food at all and drink only water. Jonathan did this in 1 Samuel 14:24. When embarking upon an absolute fast one should make sure God is calling one to do so and one should know how long the fast is to last.
- Partial fast – In this fast one is to refrain from consuming certain foods. Maybe cut out meat, maybe dessert. This is a fast that can go on indefinitely. Daniel, Shadrach, Meshach, Abednego fasted in this way; they refused to

eat the Kings meat, bread, or deserts. Listen to the results; Daniel 1:15 (NKJV) *“And at the end of ten days their features appeared better and fatter in flesh than all the young men who ate the portion of the king’s delicacies.”* This type of fast can be done by those who have health problems which would restrict them from a radical fast or an absolute fast.

- **Intimate fast** – This type of fast can be entered into by couples who decide to set aside the pleasures of the flesh to seek the Lord for a specific time period. This should only be done with the consent of both marriage partners. 1 Corinthians 7:5
- **Media fast** – I can find no scripture for this one but many people go on a media fast. This type of fast refrains from any type of media exposure for a certain time period.

CONCLUSION:

In conclusion I want to point out some perimeters for fasting. **One should not go on a radical fast or absolute fast if one has health problems which would be worsened by abstaining from food or water.**

GUIDELINES FOR A LONG TERM FAST

(On separate worksheet)

Before beginning a fast of more than three days:

- **Receive divine direction - Don't copy others; be sure you are led of the Lord as to what type of fast you are to do and how long it should last.**
- **No caffeine – Discontinue the use of caffeine a few days before the fast.**
- **Restrict your food intake several days before the fast - Eat fruit as a last meal before the fast.**

During the fast:

- **Dress warmly - You can expect to feel colder during a fast, especially in your hands and feet.**
- **Use warm, not hot, water for showers and baths.**
- **Avoid ice cold beverages.**
- **Give extra time to prayer and Bible reading.**

After the fast:

- **Avoid starches for a few days.**
- **Chew your food well.**
- **Stop eating when you feel full.**
- **Don't become physically active too soon.**
- **Eat healthy food.**

Here is a suggested schedule for reintroducing food after a complete fast:

- **DAY 1: Drink liquids every couple of hours in small amounts. Mix water with fruit juices.**
- **DAY 2: Eat chicken noodle soup or something similar. Yogurt in small quantities will be fine.**
- **DAY 3 & 4: Salads, soups without grease and cooked vegetables.**
- **After a few days you can begin to resume a normal diet.**
- **The last thing you should begin consuming is fish and meats.**